the then Thane Police commissioner, claimed that his force had arrested four LeT operatives and one of them had the same name as a militant killed in Parliament: Hamza.[7] These four terrorists were handed over to the Jammu and Kashmir Police on 8 December 2000. In addition there was a stark similarity in the blueprints, arms and ammunition seized from these four arrested in Thane and what was recovered from the slain terrorists in Parliament.

K. Rajendra, the then inspector-general of J&K Police, rebuffed Shangari's enquiries. He was reportedly quoted by a Thane daily that no such person was ever handed over by the Thane police and that Hamza is a common Muslim name.[8] He dismissed it all as a case of mistaken identity. To this, Shangari responded by saying that he had only mentioned that it could possibly be the same person because the name was common; he had not said they were the same person. Just to make sure, Shangari then sent an official to Delhi with a photograph of Hamza.

Tehelka contacted Shangari, who retired a few years ago as the director-general of Maharashtra Police. 'They were sent to Jammu and Kashmir on the orders of the Thane district court,' he said. 'I do not know what happened after that. This issue was not new. The intelligence agencies were aware of it. We send them periodic reports on these issues.' The crucial question of whether Hamza's photograph—sent from Thane— was matched with that of the slain Hamza in the Parliament attack remains unanswered.

'Mistaken identity can only be proved once we are sure of the identities. It cannot be a matter of speculation,' says Nirmalangshu Mukherji, human rights activist and author of the book *December 13.* For instance, there is no clarity till date on who Mohammad—the man whom Afzal admits having accompanied to Delhi at the behest of the STF—was. After the attack, the police claimed that Mohammad was the leader of the suicide squad, and was also involved in the IC-814 hijack in which he was codenamed 'Burger'. The police had said at that time that it would show pictures of Mohammad to the wife of Ripan Katyal who was killed by the hijackers of IC- 814. 'Burger' is believed to have stabbed Katyal on that flight. However, as per court records, after being mentioned in the charge sheet and in Afzal's confession, this move to corroborate Mohammad's identification was not followed up. So, as Haksar points out, 'In fact, we do not know the identities of the five men who attacked Parliament and were all killed.'